

Exercise: Accessible HTML Forms

Introduction

Construct a fully accessible, semantically structured contact form that collects user information, validates inputs using native HTML5 attributes, and correctly maps form controls to an HTTP request payload.

Exercise Instructions

1. Form Scaffold & HTTP Configuration

- Create a `<form>` element configured to submit via HTTP POST to the endpoint `/submit-contact`.
- Ensure the form is not nested inside any other `<form>` element.

2. Group 1: Sender Information (`<fieldset>` & `<legend>`)

Wrap the sender's identity fields inside a `<fieldset>` with a descriptive `<legend>` (e.g., "Your Details"):

- **Name Field:**
 - Add an `<input>` with `type="text"`, a unique `id="user-name"`, and `name="full_name"`.
 - Include `autocomplete="name"` and enforce input with the `required` attribute.
 - Add a paired `<label>` explicitly tied to the input via `for="user-name"`.
- **Email Field:**
 - Add an `<input>` with `type="email"`, `id="user-email"`, and `name="email"`.
 - Include `autocomplete="email"` and the `required` attribute.
 - Add a paired `<label>` with `for="user-email"`.

3. Group 2: Inquiry Details (`<fieldset>` & `<legend>`)

Wrap the message controls inside a second `<fieldset>` with an appropriate `<legend>` (e.g., "Inquiry Information"):

- **Reason for Contact Dropdown:**
 - Add a `<select>` element with `id="contact-reason"`, `name="reason"`, and the `required` attribute.
 - Pair it with an explicit `<label for="contact-reason">`.
 - Include a default disabled placeholder option: `<option value="" disabled selected>-- Select a reason --</option>`.

- Add at least three valid `<option>` elements (e.g., Support, Feedback, General Inquiry) with corresponding value attributes.
- **Message Body:**
 - Add a `<textarea>` element with `id="user-message"`, `name="message"`, `rows="5"`, `minlength="10"`, and the required attribute.
 - Pair it with an explicit `<label for="user-message">`.

4. Submission Control

- Include a `<button>` with `type="submit"` containing the text "Send Message".

5. Non-Restrictive Suggestions (`<datalist>`)

- Add an input for a "Preferred Contact Subject" paired with a `<datalist>` containing at least three suggested topics. Ensure the input can still receive arbitrary text from the user.

Reflection & Conceptual Review

Answer the following questions in a REFLECTION.md file in your exercise directory:

1. Why must developers avoid relying on placeholder attributes as a replacement for explicit `<label>` elements?
2. If an `<input>` element has an `id` attribute but lacks a `name` attribute, what occurs during form submission to the server?
3. What is the technical difference between using a `<select>` dropdown versus an `<input>` paired with a `<datalist>`?
4. Why does setting `<form method="put">` fail to dispatch an HTTP PUT request in native HTML?